

Who the Pharisees Actually Were

Four movements, one question, and a caricature the church needs to stop repeating.

CORRECTION

The Cartoon We Inherited

Say the word Pharisee in church and everyone sees the same cartoon. A sneering legalist, earning his way to heaven, crushed under rules, waiting for Jesus to expose him. I preached that cartoon. It was easy, it flattered my audience, and it was wrong.

In 1977 the scholar E.P. Sanders read the actual Jewish sources of the period and named what he found covenantal nomism. Jews did not keep the law to earn God's favor. They kept it because God had already chosen them, already rescued them, already bound himself to them in covenant. Grace came first.

Obedience was the grateful response, and repentance and sacrifice were built in for when obedience failed. Scholars still argue over the edges of Sanders' thesis, and some texts from the period fit it better than others. But the cartoon did not survive the evidence. First-century Judaism was not a religion of anxious merit. When we make it one, we are not exalting Jesus. We are inventing an opponent he never fought.

THE MOVEMENTS

Four Answers to One Question

After Antiochus desecrated the temple in 167 BC, and especially after Rome arrived in 63 BC, every serious Jew faced the same question. How does Israel stay faithful in an occupied land? The historian Josephus describes the main answers, and they map onto four movements.

The Sadducees were the priestly aristocracy. They held the temple, accepted only the books of Moses as fully binding, denied resurrection and angels, as Acts 23 notes, and made their peace with Rome because their power depended on it. The Essenes gave the opposite answer. They walked away. Convinced the temple leadership was corrupt, they withdrew into strict communities of purity and waiting, the best known almost certainly at Qumran by the Dead Sea. The fourth strand, which Josephus traces to Judas the Galilean and which later hardened into the Zealots, answered with the sword. No king but God, and no tribute to Caesar.

And then there were the Pharisees, who chose none of those roads. Not accommodation. Not withdrawal. Not revolt. Their wager was that Israel could be faithful in the middle of ordinary life, under occupation, without waiting for the politics to change. Holiness, at home, now.

RENEWAL

The Laymen Who Took God Seriously

The Pharisees were not priests. They were laymen, perhaps six thousand of them by Josephus' count, and the common people respected them more than any other group. Their project was startling in its ambition. Take the holiness God commanded for the temple and extend it to the kitchen table, so that an ordinary family's meal is eaten with the care of priests at the altar.

To do that they developed a body of oral tradition, applying Torah to trades and towns Moses never named. This was not hedging or fussiness for its own sake. It was the conviction that no square inch of an ordinary life lies outside the covenant. They believed in resurrection, in angels, in a God sovereign over history yet honoring human choice. Nicodemus was a Pharisee. So was Gamaliel, who counseled patience toward the church. So was Paul, who never stopped saying so, even in chains. And it was the Pharisees' heirs, the rabbis, who carried Judaism through the catastrophe of AD 70 when the temple parties had nothing left to stand on.

These were the people most like the serious believers in our pews. That should change how the word lands.

THE CONFLICT

What Jesus and the Pharisees Were Fighting About

So why the fire of Matthew 23? Because the quarrel was inside the family. Jesus eats in Pharisees' homes three times in Luke. He agrees with them on resurrection against the Sadducees. He tells his hearers to do what the scribes and Pharisees teach. His critique is the kind Israel's own prophets made, harsh precisely because it is close.

The collision came at specific points. Who has authority to interpret Torah. Whether holiness is protected by separation from sinners or extended by table fellowship with them. Whether the kingdom was arriving in Jesus himself, which is a claim no movement could absorb calmly. These are arguments between people who share a Bible, a covenant, and a hope.

Amy-Jill Levine has spent a career showing Christians what the cartoon costs. When the Pharisee becomes the stock villain, Judaism becomes the dark background against which Jesus shines, and that reading has done real harm to real Jews across real centuries. We do not need a slander to love Jesus. He was never that fragile.

THE MIRROR

The Scrolls and the Mirror

In 1947 a shepherd near the Dead Sea found jars of ancient scrolls in a cave. The Dead Sea Scrolls opened a window no one expected, the library of an Essene-like community at Qumran. Priests who had abandoned a temple they judged corrupt, gathered around a Teacher of Righteousness, keeping covenant with ferocious care, reading Scripture as the script of the last days, calling themselves sons of light.

The scrolls proved how varied Second Temple Judaism was. There was no single Judaism for Jesus to oppose. There were devout, competing answers to the question of faithfulness, and the gospel entered that argument as a participant, not a spectator.

Here is what the history is for. When I read Matthew 23 honestly, I am not standing beside Jesus pointing at the hypocrites. I am the religious professional in the scene. The man who loves the seat of honor, who tithes carefully and skips justice, who polishes the outside of the cup. The Pharisee is not a villain from someone else's religion. He is the man in my mirror. The text was aimed there all along.

KEY TEXTS

Acts 23:6-8

Matthew 23:1-3

Philippians 3:4-6

SOURCES

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Backgrounds of Early Christianity — Everett Ferguson